

v3 corrections. Corp jokes must PUNCH — laugh-or-cry hypocrisy, not info dumps. Surroundings described as metaphors for the people who inhabit them: the cross-street as a mouth that has eaten before, the puddles as the city's spit, the leaning buildings as the leaning citizens. No parenthetical asides. No sword mythology. Action is pure cool. Each corp moment lands as a punchline that hurts.

The Interview

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Part I — The Geometry

02:14:33. The NeoCortex catalogued the six positions in half a second.

The cross-street had been the cross-street it was tonight in seven prior engagements going back to 2218, and it had the look of a thing that had eaten before. The asphalt was patched in three decades' worth of repairs, none of them matching, like a face that had been argued over by different surgeons in different years and had stopped trying to look like a face. The streetlight at the eastern end was on a schedule. The streetlight at the western end was on a different schedule. They had stopped agreeing about midnight years ago. Somewhere between them a leaking transformer ran a fine drizzle of mineral water down the side of a substation wall that had not been wiped in eleven years, and the wall had grown a slow flat moss the color of a thought somebody was trying to remember. The buildings on either side leaned the way people leaned at the end of a long shift — not quite falling, not quite standing, working on it.

The wet asphalt held the streetlight in long orange ribbons. Kyle watched his own reflection walk through them — the katana a dark vertical line against his coat, Chorus riding his left hip — and the reflection looked, in this particular light, like a man being assembled out of someone else's spilled drink.

He gave them ten more steps.

The position on the fire escape was elevated above a panel van, the rifle's barrel finding the angle through the grating with a calmness that read as professional rather than confident. The position behind the van was the electromagnetic signature of augmented limbs bleeding through the chassis like a second heartbeat. The position behind the concrete planter was breathing through its nose in the way that took years to learn and cost more than years to maintain. The position at the parking structure mouth had augmented legs and dense chest plating — the kind of layered armor that said someone had spent real money to make this person hard to stop. One flanker behind him, unaugmented, which meant either confident or bait.

And a non-organic quadruped near the dumpster, pit-bull-sized, jaw emitter cycling at low draw, the Carrion Logistics LLC livestock signature unmistakable to anyone who had stopped to look at one — a 2218 body-pickup chassis refit for combat by a Bridgeport vendor on a flat fee that had not, on inspection, covered the cooling-system rework. The chassis was the kind of thing the second-hand market built for buyers who wanted to look like they could afford a real combat drone. It looked like one. It was not one. It was a body-pickup unit pretending to be combat hardware the way an aspiring middle manager pretended to be management. Tonight it was going to discover the difference.

The flanker was breathing through his nose. Not scared. Hadn't done this many times, or had done it so many times the body had stopped registering it as the kind of event that required fear. Kyle filed it.

He filed the spacing. The triangulation was a containment pattern he had seen before, or almost seen — Bucktown, two months ago, a crew that had let him leave when the geometry said engage. He had filed that under *unresolved* because filing it under *threat* would have required action and he had not been ready. The unreadiness was the specific cowardice between his code and his capacity, and he had been carrying it quietly, the way a man carried a small splinter for so long he had begun to call it part of his hand.

They committed on the eighth step.

The quadruped cleared the dumpster first, fast and low. The jaw emitter cycled up from idle in three-quarters of a second. The fire-escape operator dropped into position. The panel-van operator stepped into the street with the calm of someone who had been told the geometry was already settled. The planter operator stood. The armor at the structure mouth did not move — and stillness at that position meant *door*; not attack, meant *seal*, and in the 0.3-second window before Ballistic Precognition shifted from passive to active, Kyle understood that this had never been an ambush in the way he understood ambushes.

They need me breathing.

The bio-battery read seventy-two percent. The rain was cold against the back of his neck. Five chambers in Chorus — four buckshot, one slug seated in the top chamber because he had loaded it that way on the off chance he encountered the kind of door tonight a slug would solve. Six positions. One question he had been refusing to ask for two months. The quadruped's emitter at full draw. The flanker behind him no longer breathing through his nose.

Part II — Now

"Now."

The voice from behind the planter. Female. Captain register. The kind of voice used to other people doing what it said inside a quarter-second.

Kyle was already moving — not away, through — the draw completing itself in the space between her word and the rain hitting his right shoulder as the blade came over it. The blade cleared the saya in one continuous motion. He clocked her in the half-second he had: BCI at the left temple, close-cropped hair, machine pistol indexed high. Lotus south-arm, captain grade, a woman who ran containment because she trusted the geometry.

He did not answer her. The blade answered for him.

The chrome arm came at him from his right.

KT — Kira Tanaka, twenty-eight, Lotus south-arm fourteen months. The arm was a Hydraulic Solutions ARM-9, installed at the Bridgeport clinic Lotus used for that class of upgrade. Hydraulic Solutions had recalled the ARM-9 in 2222 for an elbow flexor that locked at full extension under stress. KT had never brought it in for the fix. Bringing it in required a certified identification document. Lotus had taken her identification documents in 2225 as collateral on the financing they had given her for the arm, and Lotus and Hydraulic Solutions used the same authentication protocol, which had turned out, on inspection, not to be a coincidence. Hydraulic Solutions had been a Helix subsidiary spun off in 2218 to limit Helix's liability on the ARM-7 class action. Helix and Lotus were not, on paper, related. They were related the way cousins were related at a function nobody wanted to be at. The corp that sold KT the arm and the corp that took the arm from her when she stopped paying for the arm were the same corp twice removed, and the chain had been built so that KT, on any given day, could only see one link of it at a time. The arm was going to fail tonight. The failure was on Hydraulic Solutions' books. Hydraulic Solutions would write it up as *unit operating outside specifications*. KT was outside

specifications. KT had been outside specifications since she had bought the arm.

The chrome came out elbow-to-fingertip in a full extension that telegraphed the angle. Kyle read the machete in her unaugmented right before she committed to the swing. He dropped his shoulder and the blade passed the air where his neck had been, and he turned the geometry into his — the katana coming across low and redirecting the prosthetic's mass rather than meeting it, the edge scoring chrome instead of flesh, because he needed her functional for the next four seconds and because the arm wasn't hers, not really, and that mattered to some part of him that wasn't the hardware.

She staggered.

He stepped past her toward the van.

Dex closed from behind — unaugmented, both handguns drawn, the flanker whose breathing he had clocked. The hardware tracked him at the edge of the predictive window, seven degrees outside the primary engagement cone, which meant Dex was the variable the formation was counting on.

The armor at the structure mouth — call him Rook — hadn't moved from the seal position. The rifle on the fire escape — Nines — had the angle and had not fired. The order was still *alive*.

Kyle had exactly as long as it took someone to decide the geometry was no longer worth the constraint.

The quadruped rounded the van at low profile, jaw emitter at full draw, the pre-sound filling the wet air with something between pressure and intent.

He kept moving.

Part III — The Seam

KT's arm came horizontal and he did not step back.

He stepped *into* it. Not to meet it. To find the angle the arm could not intercept.

The blade came up not to her chrome but to the shoulder seam where the chrome socket met flesh — three and a half centimeters of unprotected actuator housing exposed at the cooling vent, the same gap Helix had designed into the ARM-9 in 2221 because the cooling-vent redesign that would have closed it had been over budget and the corporation's accountants had filed the over-budget under *unfunded improvement opportunity*, a term that meant the corporation knew about the problem, had priced the fix, had elected not to perform it, and had cleared the elective non-fix through legal. Helix legal had taken eight months to clear it. The eight months were on the corporate calendar. The seam was on KT's body. Helix had decided, in 2221, that her shoulder was the cheaper option. Tonight Kyle was going to demonstrate the savings.

Tink.

The edge passed through the gap the way an edge passed through anything when the angle was right.

KT's chrome arm did not fall off. The arm did not need to fall off; the arm needed to stop receiving signals. The motor bus was severed. The arm hung dead from the shoulder. She made a sound that was less than screaming and more than nothing — the involuntary exhalation of a body that had just lost a limb it was counting on.

He stepped past her.

The captain fired from the planter — two rounds, tight, indexed where he had been standing 0.4 seconds ago. He read the muzzle before the report and stepped left. The rounds clipped the car door behind him. The metallic

percussion sounded like a man clearing his throat to apologize and changing his mind.

He clocked that she had fired. The formation's tolerance for *alive but damaged* had just compressed.

He also clocked that her call to Nines arrived late. Two words, clipped, the cadence of an order that should already have been issued. The rifle on the fire escape did not fire when the angle opened. The angle opened cleanly. Nines had the shot. Nines did not take it.

The same kind of restraint as Bucktown. *Capability without permission*. He did not resolve it. He filed it. He kept moving.

The quadruped's emitter was at full draw behind him. He felt the air pressure on the back of his neck — the inductive pulse building toward discharge — and the leg cadence shifted as the rear actuators loaded for the lunge.

He went up.

Left boot on the sedan's hood. Right boot on the windshield frame.

The emitter discharged into the air under his boot sole. The pulse arced through empty space.

Pop. Scrrrk.

The pulse was throttled. A real combat drone would have stacked the discharge and dropped him through the calf. This was a body-pickup chassis with a stun emitter the Bridgeport retrofit had cooled with a fan kit borrowed from a household appliance — the kind of corner Carrion's preferred vendors cut so that the unit they delivered looked, on its specification sheet, like a combat unit and behaved, in the field, like exactly the consumer hardware it had been made out of. The unit looked dangerous and was not. It was the corp model in miniature: pay for the brand, get the appliance. KT had paid for an arm. Lotus had paid for a combat dog. They had both gotten the household-appliance version, and they had both, in the

time they had remaining, learn the difference. Kyle dropped Chorus into his left hand. Thumb the hammer back on the slug. He put the first round through the rear actuator housing as he came off the hood.

Crack.

The legs collapsed. The dog dragged itself forward on its front pair, jaw still cycling.

He stepped past it because *halved* was enough.

Rook fired at three meters. Kyle read the shoulders before the trigger broke — the left shoulder pulling back fractionally in the way of a man trying to account for movement he expected — and stepped the angle. The round passed through the space between his right arm and his ribs with a percussion he felt in his teeth but not in his side.

The cylinder indexed the next chamber. Rook was already adjusting for the second shot. Kyle was already inside the correction.

Part IV — KT

KT came around the planter at a sprint and she was screaming something that used to be words.

The dead arm swung useless at her left side, the chrome catching the orange streetlight like a trophy she was carrying rather than a limb. The machete was overhead, both-handed grip because she had one hand that worked.

Kyle read the arc before she committed — the shoulder angle, the lean, the way a person ran when they had already decided the outcome and were simply delivering the body to the decision. He stepped inside. Not back, not sideways, *inside*.

The blade found her throat at the closest point. The cut was clean. The cut was the kind of clean the people who built him would have liked, and the thought arrived in his own voice and he filed it where he filed those thoughts: not deep, not hidden, set aside in the way you set aside something you would not examine tonight.

The blade carried through the full motion and rang off the concrete planter on the follow-through.

Tang.

KT's machete hit the asphalt with a sound smaller than it should have been.

Dex, from behind the van: "He cut KT's head off, man. He just—"

"Shut up."

The captain's voice.

Kyle catalogued the tightness in it.

Not the tightness of a captain whose geometry was failing. He knew that cadence — tactical recalculation, the compression when a plan started

costing more than projected. This was a different tightness, and it had a name he did not have access to from this angle. KT had been on the captain's cell for fourteen months. The captain had recommended the chrome to KT in 2225. The captain had signed off on the freelance-to-fulltime advancement the same Tuesday the arm had been installed. The captain had designed tonight's six-position ambush around KT's chrome because the captain had wanted to see, specifically, what Kyle would do to chrome the captain had personally invested in. The captain had not expected Kyle to take the seam in the way he had taken the seam. The captain had also not expected the throat. The captain's tightness was the sound of a person who had designed a test and had just learned what the test was actually measuring. It was the most honest sound on the cross-street tonight.

Kyle did not know any of that yet. He filed the tightness anyway. He would unfile it in five minutes.

He turned toward the fire escape.

Part V — Six Seconds

The bandoleer pouch opened on the first thumb-snap. The leather had been worn to the exact softness that meant it opened without thought, which was why Seo had built it that way. A repair-shop man's reverence for the thing the hands needed to do under stress had built him a piece of leather that did not require him to be calm to use it. Seo had been dead since 2199. The leather was the closest thing in Kyle's loadout to a friend.

Fresh moon clip — heavier than the half-spent one. Five rounds. All slug. Fragmentation tips. The kind of round you carried when you didn't know what kind of hole you would need to put through what but you wanted the hole to end the problem.

Thumbed the cylinder release. The cylinder swung out, the spent slug chamber and four live buckshot chambers exposed in the rain. He turned Chorus barrel-up. The half-spent moon clip dropped into his off-hand by gravity, four buckshot still on the clip, ringing as it dropped because the rain made everything sound clean. He dropped the spent clip into the bandoleer's catch pocket. The fresh moon clip went into the cylinder. He snapped Chorus closed. He thumbed the hammer back.

Six seconds.

He had practiced six seconds on evenings against a wall in 2F. On the kind of evening when the discipline asked for something to do besides cleaning a blade and there had not, on that evening, been anything to do besides build the muscle memory that meant tonight the procedure took six seconds and not seven.

He raised Chorus toward the fire escape.

Nines was three stories up, in profile, the cybernetic wrist-brace catching the orange streetlight at the inner forearm where the steel showed through the sleeve — the kind of brace that meant nerve damage, old injury, an arm rebuilt around the loss. Kyle put the slug through the brace junction.

Crack.

The fragmentation took the wrist apart the way a sentence ended when the grammar collapsed — not gradually, all at once. The rifle came off the grating and dropped three stories to the alley below. Nines went down on the fire escape screaming in the way that meant the arterial bleeder had already started. Two minutes to tourniquet or it became a different problem.

Kyle did not climb.

He did not call up.

He did not send the captain.

He knew what he was leaving on that fire escape. He filed it. The drawer was getting heavy. He did not examine what the weight meant. He thumbed the hammer back a second time on the next slug.

Dex broke from behind the van and ran south. Kyle tracked him for 1.4 seconds, the predictive cone painting the sprint, and then let the cone collapse. Dex was running in the way that meant he would not stop tonight. The things Dex had seen would travel faster than Dex could carry them, and that was already true, and it could not be made less true by the expenditure of a round Kyle was going to need.

The quadruped was dragging itself toward the sedan on its two functioning front legs.

The captain had not moved.

Part VI — The Dog Again

He dropped off the sedan hood as the quadruped dragged itself the last two meters. Jaw still cycling. Front actuators grinding wet asphalt. The thing's persistence was purely mechanical — no calculation in it, just the forward instruction running until it ran out. The same dumb forward of every poorly-built consumer-grade product the corporations had pushed into a working person's hand and called *enterprise*.

He let it close. At one meter he put the second round through the emitter housing at the angle the hardware gave him — not center-mass, not dramatic, the smallest aperture that ended the problem.

Crack — sccrrk.

The stun system died mid-cycle with a sound like a word that didn't finish.

The momentum carried the chassis into his shin. He stepped over it. Left hand dropped to asphalt as he caught his balance. Palm flat on the wet ground for a fraction of a second. Then up.

Part VII — Rook

Rook fired from the structure entrance. Two rounds, tight, indexed at the lower bio-battery because someone had told him where Kyle's hardware lived. Kyle read them late — the predictive window had gone 0.07 seconds latent, the bio-battery's passive draw climbing, the processing ceiling tonight lower than it had been last month. He moved through the gap in a way that was not evasion exactly. The gap was there. He found it.

The Augmentation Signature Read had mapped Rook since the structure mouth. Augmented legs, Tier 3, interface points at both hips, BCI at the right temple, no cardiac.

The corporation that had sold Rook his legs had marketed them as *flesh-compatible*. The marketing copy was true at the level of the marketing copy. The femoral artery, which the chrome intake bonded to but did not cover, was flesh. The corporation had calculated, with the kind of precision the corporation reserved for the things that made the corporation money, that *flesh-compatible* was a feature buyers would pay for. They had not asked which flesh. The flesh the marketing referred to was the flesh that survived the install. The femoral was the flesh that survived the install. The femoral was also exposed at the inside of the thigh by exactly the amount of skin the chrome did not cover. *Flesh-compatible* meant *the artery is still there and is still on you*. The corporation had not lied. The corporation had simply allowed the buyer to misunderstand.

Kyle took the last two steps inside the barrel. The slide pressed against his ribs as Rook fired. The round went into concrete below his foot. The muzzle blast burned through his shirt in a clean circle he would find tomorrow and understand as the measurement of how close he had cut it.

He catalogued the inside of Rook's left thigh.

The blade came in a precise arc — low, angled inward, the cut traveling across the interior of the thigh at the line the femoral followed below the chrome intake.

The edge passed through.

Rook's left leg, bearing his weight in firing stance, did not collapse from the cut — the chrome did not need blood to function — but Rook did, because the cut had opened the femoral. The chrome was on schedule. The flesh was not. Rook's eyes did not go blank. They went confused. His augmented legs were still trying to hold him. His body was no longer cooperating with the augmentation. He sat down on the concrete the way a building settled, not falling, descending. The pistol dropped from a hand that had become uncertain about what it was holding. He looked at the leg. He looked at Kyle. He breathed.

The chrome was not the problem. The chrome had been advertised, accurately, as flesh-compatible. And the flesh was the part Kyle had asked for.

Rook bled out at the curb in just over a minute. The leg above him kept twitching at the chrome — the corporation's product working as advertised on a man it was no longer attached to, the way a customer service line stayed on hold after the customer had died of the thing the customer service line had been holding them about.

Kyle did not stay for it. He stepped past him. He turned from the structure entrance.

Part VIII — Walking Toward The Captain

The dog was down near the sedan, jaw dark, front actuators folded in the particular stillness of drained power rather than destroyed mechanism. It would cycle back if someone reset it. Carrion would, in the morning, retrieve it and add it to the recycling backlog at the Englewood depot, where some four hundred and seventy chassis ahead of it would suggest that the unit's afterlife had time to spare. The depot was, in this respect, like everywhere else the corporations kept what they no longer wanted to look at — the same model of inventory accountability that ran the public-housing waitlist in Wicker, where four thousand people had been on the list since 2218 for apartments that did not, by the corporation's reckoning, exist.

Rook was at the curb. Nothing behind his eyes anymore. The body was doing the body's quiet work of letting the rest of itself follow the blood out.

Kyle looked at the place on the asphalt where KT's machete had landed. The sound it had made came back to him with the precision the hardware reserved for things it had catalogued as *significant without yet knowing why*. A machete was not a subtle weapon. Neither was the arm that had swung it. Neither was the debt that had bought the arm. He looked away from the machete and up at the fire escape.

Three stories. The sound Nines was making had changed register — lower now, less urgent, the direction sounds went when the body began conserving. Two minutes was an estimate. The estimate had passed.

He filed Nines in the same drawer where he had been filing things all night. The drawer was heavier than it had been when the night started. He did not examine the weight. He walked toward the captain.

She had not run.

He gave her credit for that the way he gave credit for things that cost something — without warmth, without ceremony, a fact that belonged in

the catalogue. The machine pistol was indexed low and slightly left, which was the indexing of someone who had decided not to use it and had not yet decided what to do with their hands. Her BCI was at the left temple. She was breathing through her nose. The orange streetlight was behind her and it caught the rain on her shoulders and the wet asphalt threw the light back up from below, and she looked, for 0.3 seconds, like something the city had built rather than someone who worked for it. The cross-street had been waiting for her too. The cross-street had built her along with him, just in different rooms.

He did not catalogue this. He let it pass.

The blade was in his right hand. The night was almost over. Nines had stopped making sound.

He walked toward her because she was the only thing left on this street that was still a question.

Part IX — Bucktown

"Fourteen of us jumped you in the Bucktown stretch two months ago," she said. "You walked out. We lost eight people."

The hardware did not flag the statement as new information. It filed it as *closure* — the label that fit the folder that had been sitting open for two months. The cowardice of not asking why the Bucktown crew had let him leave. The naming had not been the problem. The two months of not naming had been.

"This wasn't a hit." Her voice had something in it that was not the tightness from before. He did not have a word for it. "This was a test. I needed to see if the stories were true."

The hardware flagged the micro-expressions. Brow symmetry. Lip compression. The stillness around the eyes that belonged to people who had stopped performing and started saying something.

She was not lying.

He hated that the hardware was the thing that knew it. He would have preferred to know it himself, from the part of him that was not facility-built. That part did not have the processing speed, and tonight the processing speed was the only thing that had been earning its weight.

"They're true," he said.

The machine pistol came up.

He read the shot in the 0.2 seconds before she took it — the shoulder angle, the wrist rotation, the indexing of someone firing into a target they had already decided to keep. He did not dodge. The round hit the subdermal mesh at his left shoulder and deformed against the lattice with an impact like a fist from someone who meant it. The force traveled down through his arm and into the hand that held the blade, and the steel transmitted the shock the way steel transmitted any shock — straight through, into the floor

of his palm, into the small joints of his fingers, into the place where his discipline kept its accounts.

He kept walking.

Two meters from her he stopped.

The blade had not moved from low carry. It was the same matte-black blade it had been at the start of the night and at the end of it, and the rain ran off it the way the rain ran off everything else in this city, which was indifferently and not enough to wash anything.

"Drop the weapon."

A half-second. Her professional register found its footing. She dropped it. The machine pistol clattered on the wet asphalt the way every other piece of hardware on this street had clattered tonight.

The cross-street was now carrying somewhere north of forty thousand Φ of dead and broken cyberware between the dog, KT, Rook, and the rifle that had fallen three stories. The cross-street had not been worth forty thousand Φ of anything five minutes ago. The corporations would still be unable to pay their property tax on it. The corporations would also be the ones billing Lotus, by the end of the week, for the cleanup of the dead and broken cyberware. Carrion would do the retrieval at their standard freelance-incident rate, would charge Lotus the rate plus a twelve-percent fee for the unscheduled call-out, would bill Hydraulic Solutions for the disposal of the recalled ARM-9 components, would bill Helix for the disposal of the Tier 3 leg residuals, and would book the whole revenue stream as Q1 enforcement-margin growth. Tonight's bodies were tonight's bodies. The bodies were also, somewhere upstream, this morning's projected earnings. Lotus had paid Carrion four thousand Φ in advance for the retrieval. The retrieval would cost Carrion two thousand four hundred Φ to perform. The margin on a six-position ambush failure was, by Kyle's rough estimate, the best margin Carrion would book this week. Everybody involved was, in one direction or another, making money off the bodies on the cross-street tonight. Some of them did not yet know it.

Part X — Lotus Wants You

"Lotus wants you on payroll."

The machine pistol was on the asphalt between them. She did not look at it.

"Full protection envelope. Percentage of every contracted route through our territory. A salary the Pivot would not feel." She said *the Pivot* the way someone said a word they had looked up before they needed it. He filed that. He did not show that he filed it. "You said no the first time. I'm asking again."

He did not raise the blade. He let the rain do what it was going to do to his face. Above them Nines had been silent for almost a minute. The dog's actuators tried to cycle the broken emitter at irregular intervals, the chassis ticking at the curb, the kind of mechanical noise that did not need anyone to listen to it but happened regardless.

"No."

She nodded. The nod arrived a half-beat after a captain who had expected that answer would have produced it. He filed the half-beat. She did not press.

"Freelance roster, then." Her voice had leveled back into professional register, and he gave her credit for the speed of the recovery and nothing else. "Lotus contracts routes through our territory that need a clean face on them. You get first refusal. Carrier rates. No Lotus crew on you in the meantime."

She said *in the meantime* the way people said phrases that were doing more work than they appeared to be doing.

The arrangement she was describing lived in this — two people on a cross-street with a dead woman thirty meters behind them and a man above them spending the last of what the bleed had left him. The math was honest. The freelance roster was the smallest concession this night could end with. His

independence formally intact. The audition crews kept off him. The fee structure named plainly. No Lotus brand on anything he did or touched or was.

He had spent his life refusing to be anyone's man.

The roster was not that. The roster was a door he could close from the inside.

What the math did not say — what the math could not say — was that the Syndicate had run fourteen people into him two months ago and lost eight of them and had not stopped. Had not stopped. He filled the gap. He would not examine it tonight.

He laughed once, quietly, into the inside of his collar, where she could not see it. The audition had been an audition. The recruitment was the test result. The test result was that he had passed by killing two of the people who had designed the test. Lotus would now compensate him for the two months they had been studying him by hiring him. The world was managed by people who built systems like this and convinced themselves the systems were the only way the work could get done, and Kyle had stopped being the kind of man who argued the point a long time ago. He had become, instead, the kind of man who closed the door from the inside.

The laugh was the laugh that did not need to be funny to anyone but him. It was funny because the alternative was crying about it, and he had filed crying about it under *the work of years, not the work of tonight*, and the night had its own work.

"Fixer's name."

"Sable."

She said it without hesitation, which meant it was ready, which meant the name had always been part of the offer.

He nodded.

The name landed in the place names landed.

He did not show that it landed.

It landed in his sternum next to the hum.

The Lotus Syndicate's freelance roster ran through the same fixer whose pipeline he had been working from the cracked terminal at Otto's parts shop for two months. The fixer who had walked him into the Faraday cage four nights ago. The fixer who had built the avatar hypothesis with him in a flooded basement. The pipeline that had been delivering his contracts was also the pipeline that had been delivering Lotus's. The pipeline had not been advertising this. Sable had not been advertising this. The pipeline had been doing two jobs at once, with one face on, and Kyle was now hearing the second face named for the first time.

He filed it. He would examine it later. He would examine it carefully.

The drawer was heavy. The bed in 2F was four blocks away. The captain was still standing in the rain waiting for him to walk away from her so the rest of this could be tomorrow's problem.

He looked at the dog. He looked at Rook. He looked at the place on the asphalt where KT's machete had landed. The blade was in his right hand and Nines on the fire escape was quiet now in a way that had stopped being about the bleed.

He turned.

The cross-street opened ahead of him toward The Pivot, toward the cold broth he had not finished at Mrs. Chen's six hours ago, toward whatever the morning was going to ask of him, and he walked.

Part XI — West Erie South

West Erie south. The towers leaned into the cross-street the way they did at every elevation Kyle moved through GLMZ at — the verticality of the city pressing the rain into vertical columns wherever the air had room to move. The buildings along the route looked, at this hour, like people who had been sitting up for too long: too much weight on the load-bearing wall, the windows lit at irregular intervals the way thoughts came at three in the morning to someone who could not sleep. The block had the look of a long sentence somebody had been trying to finish for forty years.

His left shoulder registered the bruise in slow pulses. The subdermal mesh had done what it had been built to do, which was stop the round and hand the force to the tissue underneath, which had not been built for anything in particular. He catalogued it without examining it. The rain had thinned to mist. The mist caught the streetlight in ways that were not interesting and he was grateful for that.

The bike was still where he had left it behind the pharmacy on Ohio. He walked past the alley on his way north. He had walked into the cross-street tonight and he would walk out of it. The bike was for the morning.

Mrs. Chen's stall was dark. The fold-down counter was latched. The small propane burner under the left unit was cold — he knew this from three feet away because he knew the smell of it running and this was not that smell. She opened at four. He had two hours on her.

He walked past and did not slow down. The bowl he had not finished was not waiting for him, not literally. She had thrown it out. She would put a new bowl down at 16:30 and the new bowl would be the new bowl, and she would not mention the one he had not finished, and the convention would hold. That was how the arrangement worked. The work was done by editorial restraint on both sides. The corporations had not, so far, found a way to monetize editorial restraint. They were working on it. They worked on everything.

The Pivot was four blocks. The bio-battery read fifty-eight percent and cooling. The hardware was running at its ceiling and had been for twenty minutes and he knew what that meant the way you knew what a soft tire meant — that it meant something, and tonight was not the night to examine what.

He climbed the stairs to 2F. The third step from the top made its sound.

Pixel's sleep-suppression protocol came through the wall at 2E the way her music came through the wall — not loud, not intrusive, present. He read the hardware signature without meaning to. BCI at reduced draw, the rhythm of a protocol managing something rather than ending it. The protocol had cost her something to obtain through the gray-market channels she had to use because the corporation that had pulled the compound from pharmacies in 2223 had pulled it after deciding the compound was not profitable enough to defend. The compound worked. The corporation had withdrawn it from the people who needed it because the people who needed it were not the people whose insurance reimbursed at the rate the corporation preferred. Pixel paid for it out of pocket. So did everybody else she had introduced to the supplier. The corp had filed the withdrawal under *portfolio rationalization*. Pixel called it the only thing keeping her awake at three in the morning when she was supposed to be asleep, and asleep at three in the morning when she was supposed to be sleeping, and the laugh between the two definitions was the laugh of somebody whose only laugh that week was the difference.

He sat on the edge of the bed.

The blade went across his thighs in the saya. His right hand held the hilt because it was where his hand went when the night was over and he was not yet sure the night was over.

The shoulder ached in the slow specific way that would be worse tomorrow.

The deal sat in the room with him and he did not examine it and it did not leave.

Sable was the fixer.

Sable had been the fixer for two months.

Sable was now also Lotus's fixer, or had been from the beginning, and the difference between those two readings was the work he was not going to do tonight.

The drawer was heavy.

The morning was four hours away.

The bird upstairs in 3F was doing something with the building's HVAC that Pixel had catalogued as epistemological field-work and Kyle had catalogued as ambient noise. The bird worked overnight the way Pixel worked overnight. They were each other's companions in a building Kyle now realized he had been living in for four years and which he had stopped, somewhere in the second year, being able to imagine leaving.

He did not sleep.

He held the blade across his thighs and listened to the rain and watched the slow gray light start to push at the bottom edge of the window. The world was still fucked. Tomorrow was still going to be its own day. The deal sat in the room with him until the slow gray light became the kind of light he could pretend was morning.

He stood up.

The cross-street, by 04:47, was clean. Carrion Logistics LLC had been efficient. The bodies were on the schedule. The hardware was in the recycling backlog. The wet asphalt was rinsing the last of the blood into the gutter at the precise rate the rain had been engineered to produce — a rate Arcturus called *seasonal target* and the residents of the cross-street called *not enough to wash anything*, and both definitions were correct, and the disagreement between them was the entire shape of the city.

By the time Mrs. Chen opened the stall at 04:00, there was nothing on the cross-street to suggest the cross-street had been the cross-street it had been at 02:14, except for a small notch in the concrete planter where the edge of

an old katana had rung on stone. The notch would still be there in twenty years. The city would not, by then, remember which engagement had put it there. Mrs. Chen would not know to look. Sable would. Sable knew most things.

The corporations would not.

The corporations did not have a category for notches that were not on a maintenance schedule.

They were working on one.

They worked on everything.

The thing in Kyle's chest hummed once, quietly, at 19Hz, the way it always did when a day's work had finished, and Kyle, who was now learning to listen for it, heard the hum acknowledge that the night was over.

It was not.

But the chapter was.